

LESSON FOUR

KINGDOM OF GOD

Knowing God's Rule, God's People, and God's Purpose

PURPOSE

To discover what the Kingdom of God is and what it means to enter and live in it.

What is the Kingdom of God?

Who is the King?

Who belongs to His Kingdom?

How does a person enter it?

What kind of life is found in it?

Many people think of a kingdom as a place, a territory, or a government. But Scripture points to God's rule, God's reign, and God's authority over every life that submits to Him.

The Kingdom of God is not just a future hope. It is also a present reality for those who believe in Jesus, are born again, and live under His rule.

Who is ruling your life right now?

Before we open the Bible

Who is ruling your life right now?

List what actually decides your week, the people, habits, pressures, and ambitions that get the final say.

Where in that list does God appear?

Repent, the Kingdom Has Come Near

MATTHEW 3:1-2 NIV

¹ In those days John the Baptist came, preaching in the wilderness of Judea
² and saying, “Repent, for the kingdom of heaven has come near.”

MATTHEW 4:17 NIV

¹⁷ From that time on Jesus began to preach, “Repent, for the kingdom of heaven has come near.”

The message of both John and Jesus began with the same call: repent.

To repent means:

- turn away from sin
- change your mind and direction
- return to God

The Kingdom is not something we enter casually. When God's rule comes near, we are called to respond.

Already, and Not Only Later

MARK 9:1 NIV

¹ And he said to them, “Truly I tell you, some who are standing here will not taste death before they see that the kingdom of God has come with power.”

LUKE 17:20–21 NIV

²⁰ Once, on being asked by the Pharisees when the kingdom of God would come, Jesus replied, “The coming of the kingdom of God is not something that can be observed, ²¹ nor will people say, ‘Here it is,’ or ‘There it is,’ because the kingdom of God is in your midst.”

Is the Kingdom of God only something future?

It is also a present reality. Where Jesus is received as King, where His truth is believed, and where His will is obeyed, His Kingdom is present.

The Kingdom is not mainly about location. It is about God's rule.

Born of Water and Spirit

JOHN 3:1-7 NIV

JESUS TEACHES NICODEMUS

¹ Now there was a Pharisee, a man named Nicodemus who was a member of the Jewish ruling council. ² He came to Jesus at night and said, “Rabbi, we know that you are a teacher who has come from God. For no one could perform the signs you are doing if God were not with him.” ³ Jesus replied, “Very truly I tell you, no one can see the kingdom of God unless they are born again.” ⁴ “How can someone be born when they are old?” Nicodemus asked. “Surely they cannot enter a second time into their mother’s womb to be born!” ⁵ Jesus answered, “Very truly I tell you, no one can enter the kingdom of God unless they are born of water and the Spirit. ⁶ Flesh gives birth to flesh, but the Spirit gives birth to spirit. ⁷ You should not be surprised at my saying, ‘You must be born again.’”

A person does not enter God's Kingdom by religion, good works, or human effort.

Jesus said a person must be born again, of water and the Spirit.

CARRIED INTO LESSON 5

Lesson 5 returns to this passage and sets out in full what Jesus means by water and Spirit.

Who Do You Say I Am?

MATTHEW 16:13–19 NIV

¹³ When Jesus came to the region of Caesarea Philippi, he asked his disciples, “Who do people say the Son of Man is?” ¹⁴ They replied, “Some say John the Baptist; others say Elijah; and still others, Jeremiah or one of the prophets.” ¹⁵ “But what about you?” he asked. “Who do you say I am?” ¹⁶ Simon Peter answered, “You are the Messiah, the Son of the living God.” ¹⁷ Jesus replied, “Blessed are you, Simon son of Jonah, for this was not revealed to you by flesh and blood, but by my Father in heaven. ¹⁸ And I tell you that you are Peter, and on this rock I will build my church, and the gates of Hades will not overcome it. ¹⁹ I will give you the keys of the kingdom of heaven; whatever you bind on earth will be bound in heaven, and whatever you loose on earth will be loosed in heaven.”

The Kingdom of God is centered on Jesus.

He is not only a teacher, a prophet, or a good example. He is the Messiah, the Son of the living God, the rightful King.

To belong to the Kingdom is to submit to Him.

Wages, and a Gift

ROMANS 6:23 NIV

²³ For the wages of sin is death, but the gift of God is eternal life in Christ Jesus our Lord.

Sin brings death, but God offers life through Jesus Christ. One is earned and one is given. Nobody works their way into the Kingdom, and nobody is admitted without responding to the King.

The Kingdom of God is entered through faith in Christ, not through self-effort.

The Day of Pentecost

ACTS 2:1-4 NIV

¹ When the day of Pentecost came, they were all together in one place. ² Suddenly a sound like the blowing of a violent wind came from heaven and filled the whole house where they were sitting. ³ They saw what seemed to be tongues of fire that separated and came to rest on each of them. ⁴ All of them were filled with the Holy Spirit and began to speak in other tongues as the Spirit enabled them.

The Kingdom came with power, exactly as Jesus said it would.

What happens next in Acts 2 is not a private experience. Peter stands up and preaches, and the crowd is asked to respond.

The Response of the Crowd

ACTS 2:36–41 NIV

³⁶ “Therefore let all Israel be assured of this: God has made this Jesus, whom you crucified, both Lord and Messiah.” ³⁷ When the people heard this, they were cut to the heart and said to Peter and the other apostles, “Brothers, what shall we do?” ³⁸ Peter replied, “Repent and be baptized, every one of you, in the name of Jesus Christ for the forgiveness of your sins. And you will receive the gift of the Holy Spirit. ³⁹ The promise is for you and your children and for all who are far off—for all whom the Lord our God will call.” ⁴⁰ With many other words he warned them; and he pleaded with them, “Save yourselves from this corrupt generation.” ⁴¹ Those who accepted his message were baptized, and about three thousand were added to their number that day.

When the people understood who Jesus was, they responded with conviction, repentance, baptism, and obedience.

CARRIED INTO LESSON 5

Lesson 5 takes this passage verse by verse. Do not settle it here, read it, and carry the question forward.

The Life Found in the Kingdom

LUKE 23:50–52 NIV

THE BURIAL OF JESUS

⁵⁰ Now there was a man named Joseph, a member of the Council, a good and upright man, ⁵¹ who had not consented to their decision and action. He came from the Judean town of Arimathea, and he himself was waiting for the kingdom of God. ⁵² Going to Pilate, he asked for Jesus' body.

1 JOHN 1:3–4 NIV

³ We proclaim to you what we have seen and heard, so that you also may have fellowship with us. And our fellowship is with the Father and with his Son, Jesus Christ. ⁴ We write this to make our joy complete.

The Kingdom is not only personal. It is shared with God's people, who live with hope, fellowship, joy, and faithfulness.

Joseph waited for the Kingdom. The believers lived in fellowship with God and with one another.

Answer Honestly

Who is ruling my life right now?

Have I truly repented and submitted to Jesus as King?

Am I trying to enter God's Kingdom by my own effort, or by faith in Christ?

Am I living under God's rule in my daily life?

Am I growing in fellowship with God and His people?

- 01 Read these passages again slowly.
- 02 Ask God to show you where you still resist His rule.
- 03 Submit every area of your life to Jesus.
- 04 Live as someone who belongs to His Kingdom.

PRAYER

God,

Thank You for calling people into Your Kingdom.

Teach me to repent, believe, and live under the rule of Jesus.

Change my heart and help me walk as part of Your people.

Amen.

NEXT

Lesson 5

Light and Darkness

Understanding the plan of salvation, and where you stand in it